resistance that final time: we just couldn’t bear the idea of grabbing our things again and dashing for the door. As a bribe, my mother and I told my little brother he could take his prized rooster, a Rhode Island Red, a very tall, proud, strong-looking bird, and also an extremely loud one. To match that, I insisted on taking my two-storey beehive. Picture the scene: a by-now hysterical mother and her two children, along with the pride of their menagerie, stuffed into a regular station wagon and heading up the dirt track.

I had become something of an expert on beekeeping. Also an expert on how to transport them from one place to another. You have to overlay the entrance to the hive with sheets of newspaper. The bees will eventually eat their way through the paper, but, if you judge it right, they won’t get through until you’ve reached your destination. We’re driving from Melbourne to Brisbane and the kids are sleeping in the car and the bees are quietly buzzing in their hive. The sun begins to come up and the rooster wants to alert the world, but I’ve got it by the throat, and I feel this tremble, this spirit of ‘Good morning’, and all the while I can hear the bees beginning to get angry as they munch through the paper. ‘Come on!’ I’m saying to my mother, and the entire scene is a nightmare. ‘These bees are going to get through the paper and they’re vindictive!’

Eventually, we’re desperately trying to find a grassy field to let the bees out for a breather and the rooster out for a shit. And the bees are buzzing more and more and the smell of honey and wax is starting to fill the car and the rooster is crowing and we stop the car by a huge church. The rooster jumps out and dashes off, and I open the back of the station wagon and tell everybody to stand back as I prepare to rip off the tape to the entrance of the hive and let them out. The bees are raging. They need to blame something, hopefully something fluffy and brown. Obviously, they attack the rooster, and I’m secretly quite pleased. The thing is running across the field with a swarm of bees attacking its nether regions. And this goes on every day and every night until finally we reach Brisbane. There’s no God, and no sense of universal justice, either, but there is nature’s own sweet irony. Not long after we set up in Brisbane, I came out one day to see a row of cane toads, about six or seven of them, big and fat, venomous, repulsive, with bloated poison sacks on their backs, and they were sitting right there eating my bees as they came out of the hive. The Aboriginals are known to dry those poison sacks and smoke them to get high. But there was no pleasure in them for